

Understanding Arthritis Medication in the UK

A plain-English guide to arthritis medication available in the UK. Learn about paracetamol, NSAIDs, topical treatments and NHS prescriptions for joint pain.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-10 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Understanding your medication options is an important part of managing arthritis. In the UK, treatments range from over-the-counter painkillers to specialist prescriptions. This guide covers the main types available.

Over-the-Counter Options

Paracetamol

Often the first line of pain relief recommended by GPs for mild to moderate osteoarthritis pain. Available from any UK pharmacy. Take as directed – do not exceed 4g (eight 500mg tablets) in 24 hours.

Topical NSAIDs

Anti-inflammatory gels and creams (such as ibuprofen gel or diclofenac gel) applied directly to the affected joint. NICE guidelines recommend topical NSAIDs as a first-line treatment for knee and hand osteoarthritis, as they have fewer systemic side effects than oral versions.

Capsaicin Cream

Made from chilli peppers, this cream works by desensitising pain nerves. Available over the counter and may be recommended by your GP as an add-on treatment.

Prescription Medications



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Oral NSAIDs

Medications like ibuprofen, naproxen or celecoxib taken by mouth. Effective for pain and inflammation but should be used at the lowest effective dose for the shortest time, as they can cause stomach and cardiovascular side effects. Your GP may prescribe a stomach-protecting medication (PPI) alongside.

Corticosteroid Injections

Steroid injections directly into the affected joint can provide significant short-term relief (weeks to months). Usually limited to 3–4 injections per joint per year. Available through your GP or NHS referral.

Disease-Modifying Drugs (DMARDs)

Used primarily for rheumatoid arthritis and other inflammatory types. Methotrexate is the most commonly prescribed DMARD in the UK. These work by suppressing the immune system to slow disease progression.

Biological Therapies

Newer, targeted treatments for inflammatory arthritis that hasn't responded to standard DMARDs. Available through NHS specialist referral. Examples include adalimumab, etanercept and rituximab.

Getting the Right Treatment

- See your GP to discuss which medications are appropriate for your type of arthritis
- NICE guidelines recommend a stepped approach, starting with the least risky options
- Never stop prescription medication without speaking to your doctor first
- Report side effects to your GP or through the Yellow Card Scheme
- Regular medication reviews with your GP ensure your treatment remains appropriate

This article is for information only and does not replace medical advice. Always consult your GP or pharmacist about your medications.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about understanding arthritis medication in the uk?

Short answer: Arthritis medications in the UK range from over-the-counter options to specialist prescriptions. Common treatments include paracetamol for mild to moderate pain, and topical NSAIDs like ibuprofen gel. Prescription options include oral NSAIDs such as naproxen, corticosteroid injections for short-term relief, and disease-modifying antirheumatic drugs (DMARDs) like methotrexate, especially for inflammatory arthritis. Biological therapies are also available for specific cases.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk